

# St. Anselm of Canterbury's ontological argument, from *Proslogion*

## Chapter 2. That God truly exists

Therefore, Lord, You who grant understanding to faith, grant that I may understand (to the extent that You understand it [to be] advantageous) that You exist as we believe, and are that which we believe. And indeed we believe You to be something than which nothing greater can be thought. Or is there not anything of such a nature, since *The fool has said in his heart, 'There is no God'*? But surely this same fool, when he hears this very [thing] that I say, "something than which nothing greater can be thought," understands what he hears, and what he understands exists in his understanding, even if he does not understand it to exist. For it is one matter for a thing to exist in the understanding, and another matter to understand a thing to exist. For when a painter thinks in advance of what [things] he is going to make, he has them at least in his understanding, but he does not yet understand them to exist. But once he has painted them, he both has what he has now made in his understanding and understands that they exist. Thus, even the fool is convinced that there exists at least in his understanding something than which nothing greater can be thought, because when he hears this he understands it, and whatever is understood exists in the understanding. And certainly that than which a greater cannot be thought cannot exist in the understanding only. For if it exists in the understanding only, it can be thought to exist in reality also, which is greater. If therefore that than which a greater cannot be thought exists in the understanding only, this very [thing] than which a greater cannot be thought is [something] than which a greater *can* be thought. But certainly this cannot be. There exists, therefore, without doubt, something than which a greater cannot be thought—both in the understanding and in reality.

## Chapter 3: That [this] cannot be thought not to exist

This indeed so truly exists that it cannot even be thought *not* to exist. For there can be thought to exist something which cannot be thought not to exist, [and] this is greater than what *can* be thought not to exist. Hence if that than which nothing greater can be thought can be thought not to exist, this very [thing] than which nothing greater can be thought is not that than which nothing greater can be thought, which cannot agree [i.e., which is inconsistent]. So truly, therefore, does there exist something than which nothing greater can be thought that it cannot even be thought *not* to exist. And this you are, O Lord our God. So truly, therefore, do You exist, O Lord, my God, that you cannot even be thought not to exist. And rightly so. For, if some mind could think of something better than you, the creature would ascend above the Creator, and would render judgment concerning the Creator, which is quite absurd. And indeed whatever exists, except You alone, can be thought not to exist. You alone, therefore, most truly out of everything, and hence most greatly out of everything, have being; for anything else exists not so truly, and hence has less being. Why then has the fool said in his heart, 'There is no God', when it is so obvious to a rational mind that You exist most greatly out of everything? Why, except that he is stupid and a fool?

## Chapter 4: How the fool has said in his heart what cannot be thought

But how has he said in his heart what he could not think; or how could he not think what he said in his heart, since it is the same to say in the heart and to think? But if truly—or rather *since* truly—he has both thought because he said in his heart, and not said in his heart because he could not think, there is not [only] one way something is said in the heart or thought. In one way, after all, a thing is thought when the word signifying it is thought; in another way when that itself which the thing is is understood. In that way, therefore, God can be thought not to exist, in this way not at all. No one, indeed, who understands what God is can think that God does not exist, although he may say these words in [his] heart, either without any, or with some extraneous, signification. God, after all, is that than which a greater cannot be thought. Whoever understands this well at any rate understands this very [thing] to exist in such a way that it cannot—even in thought—not exist. Whoever, therefore, understands God to exist in this way cannot think that He does not exist. I thank you, good Lord, I thank You; because what I earlier believed by Your gifting, now I thus understand by Your illuminating, such that even if I were unwilling to believe You to exist, I couldn't not understand.

← Anselm's ontological argument, main version

formula for God

painter analogy: x exists in understanding  
vs.  
understanding x to exist

reductio ad absurdum

conclusion: with this formula for God, we have something that exists *in reality*

← new version? real existence + *necessary* existence?

reductio ad absurdum

conclusion: with this formula for God, we have something that cannot even be *thought* not to exist

God exists, cannot be thought not to exist

← explaining how the fool can hold his opinion

verbal thinking vs. real understanding

formula: cannot be thought not to exist  
God (via formula): cannot be thought not to exist